1
The Cave

Getting fired from Cornell was the best thing that ever happened to me. It took me too long to realize how much of a burden it was - Cornell was full of restrictions and politics that hindered my progress, all pushed by higher-ups who were more interested in shock value: “a comet set to strike Toronto in 2035” or naming a moon something “fancy”. They didn’t care about the actual research, the actual progress. The university has been turned into a gala of flash and flare instead of actually contributing to any scientific development.

I felt pathetic, like I was being laughed at, like I was being used. These sponsors wanted to name a planet after their favorite TV character and I was just the monkey with the certificate to do it for them. It ate at me, and admittedly it showed in my work. I stopped trying, I just clocked in and scribbled nonsense. I got aggressive and bitter. I’m not proud of it.

I’ve since apologized to my friends and colleagues, most of which have accepted my apologies. Though, I doubt Dr. Kutzman is willing to hear, much less accept, any kind of apology from me. In all fairness, he got the worst of my outlashes. He didn’t even make the call, he was just the poor bastard stuck with firing me; which I responded with a humble thank you, a quiet and undisturbing packing of my things, and leaving the building without a fuss - and promptly returning that same night before they had the chance to deactivate my keycard, going into Kutzman’s office and shitting in his file cabinet.

Looking back, I’m just thankful no charges were pressed. I do regret it though, Kutzman was just doing his job.

That all was 9 months ago. For the past 8 months now, I’ve been living in an RV out in the southern region of the Colorado Plateau, between Navajo and Datil. I’m surrounded by those beautiful red rock formations you see in all the western movies or on those postcards, I think called “buttes”. It really is gorgeous.

I’m living remotely out here but not completely alone; Dr. Mara Fischer and Ron Gaffer are posted out in similar RV’s at different corners of the desert, each about an hour away from myself and each other, doing research of their own. I wouldn’t be out here without them.

I had known Mara for a while, she told me about their privately funded research program. Ron, the spearhead of the program, interviewed me, and a couple of weeks later I was brought out and provided with all the equipment I need. An RV, a vixen telescope, and a work computer connected to data from a university satellite. All that and a weekly supply drop of food and water was everything I could ask for. I’ve been busy and happy ever since.

***

A few days ago, I thought I discovered a new asteroid. Easy enough - analyze it, classify it, name it and upload the information to a connected account where Ron, Mara and I can see each others' work.

I was stopped at the first step of the process: analyzing it. There were no signs of any stone or metal on this thing. In fact, there were no signs of carbon found at all - it was missing all the physical signs of an asteroid. I noted this and marked it down as an "unidentified" finding, named it "Otto" for no reason other than I thought it sounded good, and uploaded it to the account.

The next day, I continued my research and again I picked up the same unidentified thing. I wasn't looking for it, but I received several alerts from the satellite for a "new subject found", and when I checked on it the "new subject", there it was.

Normally an asteroid, or anything moving through space at its trajectory, would be gone from its position after a day. When I looked, it had only moved over a couple of constellations west. Still moving, but very slowly. I reopened the file I had made the day prior and added the new information I had found. I also marked down the positions I had seen it at on a star chart Mara gifted me.

The day after, I looked through my telescope actively looking for it, and I found it. It was resting perfectly still in space exactly where it had been idling the night before.

There were no signs of anything that had come in contact with the object, no signs of any external forces that had brought it to a stop, it was simply there. Perfectly still. Even unmoving, the satellite was still picking up alerts for "new subject found". Multiple. One after the other, every 6 seconds, like clockwork. "New subject found". I restarted my computer and it changed nothing, the alerts continued. It felt intentional, like a phone ringing.

How does one answer a phone in the form of celestial motion alerts?

I knew I could send out a signal called a "confirmer". The satellite will send out a radio wave to a nearby satellite to check in and make sure it's active, if it is then it will respond with a confirmation or a "flaw". If whatever it was could intercept radio waves, it might be able to react, otherwise the nearest satellite that would get the confirmer would be Mara's. She has a secondary university sponsor that granted her access to their satellite as well (she earned it but I'd be lying if I said I wasn't jealous). She might ask about the confirmer but as long as I tell her it's just me doing a routine check then it should be fine.

Another alert and I sent out the signal.

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FLAW.

Flaw. Not what I expected to receive, but this could mean something interesting. The alerts continued, “new subject found”.

I sent another confirmer.

1…

2…

FLAW.

Quicker this time. Almost instantaneous, not like a satellite, but the response was intentional. After the flaw response, I waited and I didn’t hear any alerts. 6 seconds passed, then 12. I waited a minute and there was nothing.

Again and again I sent confirmers out, all receiving **FLAW** within a second. Between each confirmer, I left a couple of minutes to wait and see if another alert would sound and it never did.

I rushed outside to my telescope, positioned exactly as I had left it; aimed at the object. It was still there - *thank god*. Perfectly still.

I stared through the telescope for a long while, just wanting to see it with my own eyes. It was round but imperfect, like child's drawing of a circle, and it had a faint halo surrounding it making it barely visible in the darkness. I thought of a hundred things I was positive that it couldn’t be, but had almost no theories as to what it really was. It was mysterious and beautiful.

I returned back to my computer ready to shut down, but the fear of waking up and the object no longer being there froze me. It had appeared without warning, there was nothing I could do to keep it from vanishing the same way. But it had lingered this long, I could hope that it would still be there tomorrow.

In a desperate act, I did the only thing I could think of that might have any effect on the object; I opened a GPS signal. If anyone or anything is accepting radio signals nearby, they will know where I am. And if it really was the object responding to the confirmers it should be able to receive this signal somehow. I looked back outside once more, confirmed that the object remained still, returned inside and went to sleep.

***

I woke up to 1 missed call from Ron and 3 missed calls from Mara with the most recent one having been 5 minutes ago. I called her back.

"Howard?" Mara asked loudly.

"Morning Mara. Everything ok?" I responded, wiping the sleep from my eyes.

"*I'm* fine, but you left a GPS signal open all night, you're using up a lot of power. I only saw it when I woke up, is everything ok?"

"Oh!" I had to think of a lie fast, "Yeah, I'm alright, I was just making sure it worked. I tried to send out a bunch of confirmers last night and it wasn't working right. The GPS was all I could think of."

It was a stupid excuse but it was enough to ease Mara's mind. And it was only a small lie.

"Next time just restart the system or ask me and Ron for advice. I was worried you needed help, like you were bleeding out or something."

"Not bleeding out, just wasn't using my head." I laughed and heard Mara do the same on the other end.

"Use it next time, ok?" She spoke with less tension in her voice.

"Of course. Will do."

"Good. Have a good day. I'll let Ron know you're doing ok."

"Thanks Mara." I hung up the phone, quickly went to my computer, not stopping to put on pants, and shut off the GPS signal. Just after, I sent another confirmer.

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5…

CONFIRMED.

The green notification appeared on my screen followed by a text from Mara saying: "It's working now!" with a thumbs up.

But why? Had the object left? The fear I had felt the night before flared up again and I walked out of the RV - getting instantly flashed by the hot Colorado sun. I held my hand up to my brow to block the sun as I moved to the telescope and looked through.

It was too bright, I couldn't see anything but the sun and the few clouds roaming the sky. I'd only be able to find out if the object was still above me or not.

It took 10 hours for the sun to fully set behind the plateau but it felt like 20. I was distracted all day, it felt like I was back at Cornell; unfocused and frustrated. I hardly ate, which didn't help, but I did put on pants.

I was staring at my computer screen as the satellite picked up a sum total of nothing when the alarm I had set finally went off. Looking out the window, I saw only black and I knew it was time.

I took a moment to relax - new and exciting things pass every day and it would do me no good to linger on disappointment. But damnit I hope to god it's out there.

I don't know why I want to study it so bad. Maybe it's just a new passion, something new and fascinating that I can hyperfixate on for a while, maybe put my name on it and talk about it at a university; not Cornell.

I walked out of my RV and heard the crickets chittering. I felt comforted by the night, it wasn't harsh. I felt like even if I didn't see the object I would be alright and I could move on.

But I did see it.

Not through the telescope, but by looking up to the night sky. Floating above me was an amorphous orb of darkness and starlight, it was hard to make out details with just my glasses but I could tell that whatever it was, it was tangible.

Slowly, without taking my eyes off of it, I moved over to the telescope and adjusted its position to look at the orb. I shifted the distance and the focus to work better in close proximity. Looking through, I could see it clearly:

It was a sphere of thick black vines or tendrils that appeared to be slowly and constantly turning in on itself to a place I could not see. The tendrils varied in size, some protruded out further from the middle than others causing a number of small imperfections. As I stared at it through the telescope, I realized it was moving steadily down, out of view of the lens. I followed it with the telescope and it continuously moved closer and closer to the ground, no more than a quarter mile out from my position.

Then, it stopped.

As it hung still a few yards above the ground, I held my breath, waiting to see what it would do. In the stillness, I realized its true size - it was like a house, maybe 50 feet all around.

After several long moments of quiet air and no hint of movement other than its writhing tendrils, I looked up from the telescope and moved closer to it. I took a few careful steps, waiting to see if it would react. It had no eyes, ears, or humanoid features to speak of, I wasn't sure what it would respond to - other than radio.

I began to walk steadily. At this pace I would reach it in 10 minutes. I could hear my heart beating in my chest but I didn't stop. I didn't even blink, my eyes remained wide and fixated on the object looming above me.

I was stopped dead in my tracks as a deep and guttural roar sounded out from the object. I covered my ears but it hardly helped, it was so loud I thought Mara or Ron would be able to hear it from their posts; gusting sand and dirt blew out in all directions from beneath the object as its call continued.

My body trembled as I fell to my knees and my glasses dropped from my face. My hands clutched to my ears and my eyes shut hard.

The violent cry sounded for no more than a minute. When it ended I felt like I had been winded; I slowly removed my shaking hands from my ears as I sputtered, catching my breath like I had been drowning. I scrambled to pick up my glasses, newly caked in dust, and put them back on before looking back up to see that the object had moved. Not far, it was still in sight, but it was moving away from me.

I stayed on my knees and watched it as it moved to a nearby butte. As it approached the butte, its tendrils lengthened forward and down towards something I couldn't see, and slowly it seemed to unravel itself and vanished somewhere at the lower part of the butte.

I rose up from my knees but I didn't wait to see if it would move again, I just started running. It was a demanding several minutes, I'm used to sitting behind a desk and almost never make time for exercise, but this was worth running for.

I made it to the foot of the butte, wheezing exhasporatedly. The rock loomed high and intimidatingly above me but I was only concerned with what lied below.

I didn't need to walk much before I saw where it had nestled; a cave, tall and jagged. I stared into the mouth of the cave, decorated with dark tendrils that stuck to the walls, guiding me to the abyss within. As I gazed into the maw, my mind began to settle. The object seems to have found a comfortable space, it had no reason to move, I could research it without worry.

I found myself moving closer to the cave without a thought. I didn't stop as I realized I was moving, I didn't want to. I pressed on. With a step between me and the object, I could smell

something sour and rich like old meat, and I felt a strong warmth emitting from deep within and heard a quiet humming, like hot breath. Staring forward, the butte beyond my peripheral, I saw only darkness. I was comforted by it.

I took the step.

What followed was intense and hard to describe. It felt like being flashed by the sun, something harsh, bright, and disarming.

I was looking at dozens of stars, not through a telescope, but as though I was in space with them, observing them up close. One after the other I looked at the stars burning and rumbling in fiery chaos before instantaneously appearing before another and the cycle repeated. As I jumped between the stars, deep engrained lessons of vocabulary from as far back as elementary school blinked in my mind faster than I could question why.

A bright burning star - *phonics*.

Another one at an indeterminable part of the galaxy - *tenses*.

Again and again - *synonym*, *definition, command*.

The cycle repeated on and on I don't know how many times, but the heat and the soft humming was constant through it all, constantly ringing in my ears until I woke up in my RV.

The memory felt like a dream; I could only remember it through faint bits and pieces of it and by noon I would probably forget the entire experience. I rose from my bed, looking around to see if anything had changed. My clothes were the same as they had been the previous day, only now covered in dirt and sweat stains stretching down my front and back.

I moved through my RV to the only thing I noticed appeared different; my desk. There were papers and pencils scattered all around it, the computer was moved to the floor, and the star chart now had several dozen stars marked, named, and accurately identified - all in my handwriting.

I spent the next hour analyzing every piece of data I had apparently written down. There is no source of how I found these stars, no explanation as to how I knew what they were, but I looked through all of the subjects I had identified and every single one was confirmed. And somehow, some way, I had done it all in one night.

I have no memory of this, I only remember the stars, but looking through the papers repeatedly I can't deny the truth. It's my best work yet.

2
The Cooler

It's been nearly a month and I've returned to the cave 14 times.

Ron and Mara had no idea of its existence as far as I could tell, only me.

At first I resisted going back, truly I did. I didn't know what it was, what it wanted or what it could do - to me or to anything else.

A week, I think, was all I managed before my curiosity bested me. I continued my work but it just couldn't measure up to what I had done in my state of unconscious, even Mara took notice. She sent me a few messages checking in on my wellbeing, asking if I was staying hydrated and getting enough sleep - the answer to both was no, but I lied convincingly enough. Once she had confirmation of my welfare she would go on to scold my work:

"Howard, I could finish a report like this in an afternoon, why is it taking you 2 days?"

"Howard, I've already charted this region. Read my reports next time so you can make your own discoveries."

"Howard, do a grammar check on your reports before you submit them, this is high school level."

On and on like so. It was irritating but well deserved, my work *was* lacking. I don't know if it was the lack of rest, if it was something that happened that night I went into the cave, or if my work had always been mediocre. It was the last of those possibilities that put a knot in my stomach, the fear that there was no change other than my perspective to finally see what a piss poor excuse for an astronomer I really am.

What finally got me was a message from Mara saying:

"Heads up: I'm coming down to check on you. Next open day I have is in a week, I'll see you then."

I felt like a child failing a class being reprimanded by a parent. I tried again to better my work but in comparison to my other recent reports I saw no improvement, and I was certain Mara wouldn't either.

Later, I tried to sleep but failed at this too. My recent shortcomings kept eating away at me, guilt and shame wracking my brain. *Incompetence*, the word kept ringing in my ears like an annoying

ring tone I couldn't shut off. The frustration with myself paired with a childish resentment against Mara for her incessant (though accurate) reprimands proved to be a brutal cycle.

I remembered my last few months at Cornell, absent mindedly typing away my papers, submitting them without review, and accepting my payment every 2 weeks. It was trivial, boring, at some times very deeply depressing, but it was easy. *God, it was so easy*. And I had gotten away with it for years. *Years!*

Was I missing it? Was I not ready for this much freedom, this much autonomy and self reliance? No one to blame but myself, if there is a mistake on the report it's my own doing.

On one hand I didn't have a team of suits ordering me from one project to another, making my work less research and more marketing, but on the other I felt lost. Like I had been on a sinking boat for so long and when I finally jumped off I found myself in the middle of the ocean with no idea of where the nearest island was. *Which was worse, being stuck or lost?*

I checked the clock. It was nearly 3 in the morning and I was spiraling.

I had taken some melatonin but it wasn't working. I positioned myself in my bed like I was a cadaver at an open-casket funeral and I began taking slow deep breaths with my eyes shut; I heard that this helps settle the mind and put you to sleep and oddly enough I felt it working. The panic began to melt away, remnants of stress lingered in my tense muscles but otherwise my mind was going quiet.

I thought of easier times: Cornell, Aimsborough High School, road trips around the states with my old college friends, *with Mara*. My panic returned momentarily at the thought of her impending wellness check, but the dread was neutralized by the memory of another easy moment,

The cave.

Whether it was true or not, the memory of the cave whisking me away to absent genius, placing me in bed to wake up well rested with hard work well done felt like the easiest day of work since I've been out in this desert. Maybe the easiest moment of my career.

It was still my work after all, I just didn't know what I was doing. And it was damn good work.

The fear of the unknown kept me from returning up until now; the fear had turned to allure. *But I don't know what it is*.

Another damned counter, another fucking contrast, an argument, a pissy reason not to do something. All of the nauseating frustration had turned to anger - I was *tired*. And I was tired of not doing anything. I'm a damned scientist, scientists *research*. We hypothesize, we experiment, we gather the data and we report. I'm wasting my talents on sub-par reports when I could be gathering first-hand information on extra-terrestrial material.

I opened the cooler beside my bed and pulled a lone bottle of rum from the ice, gifted to me by Ron after he completed a particularly daunting project - gifted alcohol for himself, Mara, and me. He's a good man.

Any trace of sleep I felt was gone, I felt my heart beating hard again. I undid the cap of the bottle and took a long drink, the smell of rich spice filling my nostrils as streams of caramel colored liquor spilled down my chin. The drink burned my throat and my chest, I didn't like alcohol but it gave me that needed boost of courage.

I turned my computer on and put my equipment out on the desk before stepping out of the RV into the warm night air. My eyes locked onto the butte the object had nested in a week prior. It was hard to make out any finer details with only moonlight but even from so far away I was sure I could see hints of dark stalks peaking out of small corners.

I left my door open and marched down to it, gathering sand and sweat and dust on my clothes which were already messed by the haphazard swig of rum.

It was a long walk from my RV to the butte, long enough for me to think about what I was doing but I didn't want to turn back. *Just do it, just do it, just do it*...I was sick of second guessing myself. I was capable of good professional work, I knew I was, there was just a missing piece keeping me from putting out my best material. Whatever that missing piece was; motivation, formatting, wording, some vague element I was forgetting - It *could help me remember*.

I was at the mouth of the cave again, staring into the darkness. The object was still there.

The desert was quiet and so was I. Only small noises were emitted by the object, droplets of liquid echoing from deep within the belly of the cavern to the open mouth where I stood, gentle shifting and tensing of the stems that formed the being as a whole like it was getting comfortable. Even just standing in front of the cave, a hot gust of wind brought the scent of over aged meat back to my nose. I shivered.

"Hello." I said to no one, and received no response back. "I'm back."

The nothingness was either incapable of speaking or had no care to say anything back.

"You helped me with my work when I came to you…*thank you*." I left open pauses between my sentences in case anything chose to respond in any way. "My work is very important, to me, my friends, and all of the world really. I chart the stars, I discover far off objects in space and share my findings with everyone. I technically discovered *you*."

Talking oddly brought me some comfort, some justification in my actions. I began moving in steadily as I spoke, it felt like I was inviting myself into someones home, "You see, I need your help again. Ever since I came to you my work has been…unimpressive. I can't seem to replicate what *we* did together. Though, I'm not sure entirely what it was that we did, I'm quite happy

with the results. I'd like to do it again…please…" I stepped further in, the object was humming again just as it had done last time. Wherever the throaty tremors were coming from, it was deep within. It was at this moment I realized that I had trekked deeper into the cavern than I had previously. *It was letting me*.

"If you'll have me, I know that we can do -"

My words were cut off by a sudden numbness in my knees and neck that I felt only briefly before falling unconscious.

Then, once more, I found myself in space and I was faced with tens upon tens of smouldering stars flashing fast before me. And, just as last time, with every star came an old relic of knowledge from the corners of my mind:

Computer - Chart - Map - Work - Mara.

Work - Space - Research - Science - Write.

Research - Ron - Rum - Cooler - Heavy.

Ron - Desert - Telescope - See - Asteroid.

Asteroid - Discovery - Object - Otto - Otto.

Otto - Otto - Otto - Otto - Otto.

Intersplicing the visions of grand celestials was the jagged memory of my initial report on the object and the name I had offered it offhandedly.

I awoke at my desk. The computer was still on, I was using a loose scatter of many papers as a pillow, and my clothes clung uncomfortably to my body with a thick layer of sticky sweat. My door was still open and I could see daylight pouring through, it must have been about midday.

I felt as though I had come to from a very pleasant and long sleep, but I wiped the tired from my eyes, as well as a small dribble of dried blood that seemed to have come from my nose at some point in the night, and scrambled to look at the papers and whatever was on the screen of my computer.

The first time I had delved into the cave I emerged having 19 new notable discoveries. Since then, my daily average was anywhere between 3 and 10. Between my computer and the papers printed out on my desk I had 32 new grand and accurate discoveries, all formatted perfectly as though it had been produced by a computer. A laugh of shock broke out of me. *32*.

I flipped through the papers in disbelief, each celestial body written down had exact coordinates, descriptions, and noted elements found in them. Knowledge that would take weeks to gather I had rounded in my sleep in several hours.

I organized the sheets into 2 piles. A neat stack of 27 professionally developed papers (undercutting my initial impress of the staggering 32 only slightly), and 5 papers marked front and back by one word: *Otto*.

I still wasn't sure precisely what the object planted in the cave was; alive and thinking, plant or animal. It was mysterious and intimidating, and I'm not sure if I would be able to accurately devise what it is - or if it would let me.

What I did know for certain was it worked with me, it helped me produce my finest product and seemed to ask nothing of me.

It was smart, it was symbiotic, and it wanted to be called Otto.

***

I've devised a system that works for me and keeps Mara and Ron unsuspecting.

All of my work is done by hand now, written papers and findings all still formatted properly and stars marked accurately. I take the findings and upload them slowly over the week so that it looks like I'm finding up with the data as I'm researching. I'll upload anywhere between 5 to 10 reports a day; a plausible amount but still impressive. I've received a few compliments from Mara and Ron saying my work has really improved.

I'm now surer than ever that I need Otto for my work to reach its best quality. I don't know what I was doing before him but it couldn't hold a candle to the work I produce now.

I realized I needed to find an alternative method to uploading my work after found myself with 192 total new discoveries after my past several meetings with Otto. Not all of which are what I expected, however. 119 are of celestial bodies and discoveries useful to astronomers, the other 73 are more obscure and I'm still trying to devise. I'll explain soon.

The work load has been a bit overwhelming and my wrists are hurting much more lately since switching over to handwritten reports. I've come to terms with the fact that every time I visit Otto I can expect to wake up sweaty, likely with some dust on my clothes, a full body ache, and for the past 3 visits - a bloody nose and a light headache.

Otto is fascinating to me. Our relationship seems to be mutually beneficial and yet we haven't had any intelligible conversation.

Now that I no longer need to spend time tediously researching before sending in my reports, I fill that empty time with studying Otto from the outside. I write down what I remember of my episodes when I come in contact with him, I write down descriptors and notable features that help me understand Otto better as another material being instead of something otherworldly; try and dissolve my bespelled illusion of him and study him like any other experiment.

I've learned very little, and it's maddening.

Otto appears to be an animal entity - the tendrils of his that cover the walls of the cave undulate, very subtly and in rhythm like it's breathing or shifting as to prevent discomfort. I can't identify exactly what the humming it emits is, but my working theory is that it's a form of lure, like how angler fish use a hypnotic light to entrance other fish. The hum has similar effects to THC (which I've studied thoroughly in my college years); the wider expanse of thought melts away, there is only a singular stream of consciousness that captivates your focus and dictates your actions - in this case, entering the Maw of Otto.

Another curious feature of note is the difficulty it takes to spot Otto when you're not looking for it; originally I thought it was an issue on my end; the light, my eyes going worse than they already have, poor peripheral vision, maybe one of those obscure tricks your mind plays on itself. It's not, it simply can't be any of those. The strange fog inhibiting my periphery appears to be exclusive to Otto, regardless of how close or far I am from him. I could be facing Otto head on but if I turn my eyes a little too far up, down or to the side it's like he vanishes from view. I'm not sure what this phenomena is, it's not quite tunnel vision. I've dubbed it "*Autonomous Periphery Manipulation*", a very simple title for something I can hardly explain but it works.

Otto hides in plain sight by doing nothing but subtly manipulating others vision, once someone stumbles upon him they are drawn in by the hum - the lure - and when they are deep within the cave they are placed in some form of sleep-like trance. For me, when placed in this trance I become exceptionally productive while seeing stars. While I'm still working out the why and how I'm seeing the stars, I've been deciphering why I secondarily recollect obscure lessons during these trances.

When I first went under I was shown stars but I also distinctly remember lessons of vocabulary and basic language comprehension. Each time I visit Otto a new lesson is brought to mind; most recently I found myself thinking about eggs, dairy, wheat, and a slew of other ingredients.

There have only been a few rendezvous' with Otto where I was left confused after our meeting. Instead of the usual montage of heavenly bodies I'm exposed to, I'm faced with images of phenomena I find hard to explain and haven't seen anywhere on our earth or within the parameters our telescopes can reach. I remember seeing images of a tree-like thing with midnight blue bark with no extending branches, only a strange star-like split at the top of its phallic shape. In the report I was able to find of it when I woke I read that it was a parasitic plant; its roots drank up any water nearby and helped it grow to extraordinary sizes, and the greater it grew the greater the star-split at the top peeled open, revealing a sweet nectar on the inside to attract lesser animals and insects for it to feed and pass off spores to.

Another time I awoke with a report about a bulbous mosquito-like creature that drank its fill of various juices and fluids. Once full, it would mix its DNA into the liquid-retaining shell in its body to then spit out into fertile ground to create some kind of concoction that would produce a

floral plant that spawned other grotesque, round, flying insects. A life cycle I had again never heard of before and have yet to find any matches for online.

73 papers out of 192 dedicated to plants with bizarre coloring and behaviors, animals with oddly shaped figures and unconventional mannerisms; all of which I spent good time attempting to research and finding nothing but a variety of blogs discussing theories of xenobiology and new mutations in earths ecology caused by toxic waste and GMOs.

I've given these 73 papers their own pile. It's hard not to think about them but I need to focus on my work.

I'm not always able to remember in full what my secondary thoughts were, it's like trying to remember a dream after waking up, but I believe there's a reason for that.

I believe the secondary thoughts coming to mind are for Otto. While Otto shows me the stars and a slew of other strange and otherworldly specimens, I show him my breadth of knowledge of the world - a trade, one that I'm happy to make.

Around sunset I get a message: Mara.

"Coming tomorrow. Glad to see my threats of wanting to check up on you seem to have worked haha."

I had forgotten entirely that she was planning to visit. Why couldn't she just leave me be? My work had improved, I had solved the issue.

Maybe I was over reacting. Maybe Mara's visit would be more of a friendly drop-in and less of a professional review; after all, her most recent message seemed more lighthearted than the others. I shouldn't worry more than I need to. But precautions are always wise.

"What time should I expect you?" I responded.

A while passed.

"Noon sound good?"

Noon. I could work with noon.

"I'll see you then!"

I set my phone down and checked the time: 7:39pm.

The average encounter with Otto lasts roughly 8 hours and I would want at least 2 hours to myself in the morning to gather myself and prepare for her visit. I could time it out - if I manage to keep busy for another 4 hours I could visit Otto at midnight, wake up around 8, and have plenty of time to unwind before Mara visits.

It's just a cordial visit.

I did as I planned - I filled 4 hours with miscellaneous cleaning and sorting until the clock hit midnight when I exhaustedly wandered my way to Otto and entered the maw.

I was lulled into a sense of peace, like coming home after a long business trip. My delirium lingered as I trudged deeper into Otto - *it's taking longer than normal*. I continued deeper until I could feel my head vibrating with the low hum. This was further than I had ever been, I could make out the shape of an opening before me as my eyes began to blur - it was setting in.

The moment before I slipped away I could swear I saw a few outstretched tendrils of Otto reaching out for me.

***

Morning was long and tedious. I wiped the blood from my nose that had dripped down to my lips and quickly stacked the papers of the star logs with the others in a cabinet under the sink. I washed my face and changed my clothes and after that I had nothing to do but wait.

I ate a small breakfast though I had no appetite and prepared a lunch for Mara's arrival. My body felt tight, I felt nauseous, I didn't want any visits. Maybe I'll feel different when she's actually here, or maybe I'll have to find a way to get her to leave quickly. Either would be doable.

Maybe she'd be interested in Otto.

No, I can't risk showing him to anyone else. Who knows how they'd react to him, or he to them? What if they preferred each other over my company? Mara was an incredibly intelligent woman, beyond my knowledge…if she and Otto were to meet somehow who's to say he wouldn't accept her and disregard me?

It had been a short while I had known Otto, and in that time I had never shared him with another person. The thought was unnerving. There was a chance he could accept the both of us, I had seen no evidence proving otherwise, but it was too big of a risk for me to chance.

I was snapped out of my stressed haze by the faint sound of rumbling outside. I walked outside of my RV and found Mara driving a white boxy offroad 4 by 4 car, its tires and sides caked in sand and mud. She drove it to the base of the mound I was set up on, exited the car and walked up to me.

She wore large rectangular glasses that complimented the shape of her face well, as did her wavy brown hair that reached down just past her jaw. Mara and I were wearing nearly identical outfits - black cargo shorts and white shirts. The biggest difference in our appearance was the smile Mara dawned in contrast to my poor attempt to look normal.

“Howard, are you feeling alright? You look like you need to use the bathroom.” Mara asked as she finished her walk.

Her joking tone helped ease my mind, “No, I’m ok. I just haven’t seen you in a bit, it’s nice.”

“It’s nice to see you again too.” She smiled and I hugged her, albeit rather abruptly, but thankfully she didn’t seem too off put by it.

“Come in, please.” I guided her into the RV. I was waiting for her to point out something I had missed, something I had haphazardly left out in the open for her to notice and question me on - for which I’d have to come up with a lie for, or worse tell the truth.

Thankfully, nothing of the sort happened. She threw herself on the couch and exhaled deeply, like she had just run a marathon.

“Is it alright if I hang out until the sun starts going down? I hate traveling in the heat.” Mara picked up a stray book and began fanning herself. I can’t imagine it worked very well.

“Of course, but if you wanted to avoid the heat you shouldn’t have come to the desert.” I smiled, sitting myself on the opposite end of the couch. I had checked the night before, sundown was around 8pm tonight. I wasn’t thrilled about the idea of hosting her for so long but I could do it.

Mara took a beat to cool herself down enough before sitting up and speaking in a more serious tone, “I just want to get right to it…should I be worried about you?”

“Why would you need to be worried about me?” I responded innocently - if I know exactly what she perceives as the problem I can lie accurately.

“Howard,” She scoffed, “you had a major dip in the quality of your work a couple of weeks ago, you don’t say anything to me or Ron. Then out of nowhere you are back with consistent high quality stuff - which is *great*…but neither me or Ron knows what the hell was going on with you.”

I paused and nodded in understanding before answering her, “I wasn’t happy with my work. I felt like I was stuck making the same bullshit I was doling out at Cornell and the whole reason I came out here was to be better than that. I was too busy feeling sorry for myself and it made my work even worse.

“Once *you* started getting on my ass about it I realized the only thing worse than putting out my worst work is being called out for it.” I could see Mara crack a smile from my periphery, “So, I set up a routine for myself. A way to do better consistently, and so far it’s been working…I think.”

"It has been working, don't doubt that." Mara squeezed my shoulder as a gesture of comfort, "But, Howard, your work was never bad."

Now *she* was lying, "My work may not have been bad but it wasn't very good and you know it."

"Why the hell would I ask you to come all the way out here if I thought your work was bad, or just '*ok*'?"

She had a point. Mara was kind but she was honest too, if she didn't like you, your work, or your attitude she'd let you know. Even if she was your friend.

She continued, "You did good work from the beginning. You just had a slight dip in quality or productivity or confidence - whatever it was, it was momentary. But it seems like you're all good now."

Mara's words of encouragement helped. I was always good at what I did, I just needed to find a good groove. Maybe I didn't need Otto.

Maybe I didn't need Otto back then.

Now, if I were to stop visiting the cave, cut him off altogether I couldn't say what would become of my work. After one time of visiting Otto my work quality plummeted, but I've been seeing him consistently for a while now. If I stopped now it might be like trying to learn the whole practice over again from scratch.

Mara's words were kind, and I may have always been good at what I did, but I'm better now.

"Thank you, Mara. I needed to hear that."

***

Hours passed and I actually found the time I was spending with Mara to be rather enjoyable. It's easy to forget how nice the company of others is when you don't see many people.

The sun had set, it was about 9:30 now, but we were still enjoying catching up. We had moved the conversation outside of the RV to some lawn chairs under the awning, next to my telescope. Mara had also taken note of the barely used bottle of rum Ron had gifted me and refused to let it go to waste. The rum and the cooler it lived in sat between us, now with only about a quarter of it left to drink.

Its contents had been evenly split between us, and though I couldn't speak on Mara's behalf I could feel my inhibitions slipping significantly.

I was laughing harder, my face was red, and my head felt heavy.

In simple terms, *I was really fucking hammered*.

I had missed Mara, we had a lot in common. Over the hours we had talked about subjects ranging from our work, politics, movies, old friends, high school drama we lived through. It all flowed very naturally, she's a good person.

I had found myself missing Ron too. He was a quieter man, harder to read, but in an out of work setting he's always the funniest person in the room. I should call him tomorrow and see if I can find time to spend an evening with him like the one I'm spending with Mara now - or better yet, find a way to get the both of them.

Mara was finishing a story about how a rat had made its way into the cleanroom of the lab she used to work for when my ears began to ring. Mara's expression softened a bit,

"Howard, are you alright? Did you drink too much?" She asked, only partially joking.

I wasn't sure what was happening. I didn't feel pain, just a sharp high pitched whine emitting from somewhere between my ears, "I think so, just a weird sound."

After a beat Mara noted, "I was asking more about the blood."

The blood? Sure enough, a drip of warm blood had dripped from my nose and into my nearly empty glass. Was I sick? Had I drank too much?

My mind scrambled for answers as Mara hurried to find some kind of napkin or tissue and water to nurse me when a sound howled out in the night, dwarfing the strange ring.

The violent guttural cry - the very same I had heard when Otto first arrived in the desert. At first I heard it bellowing from the back of my skull, sending tremors to the back of my eyes, but it evolved to a noise outside of me, coming from the cave.

Mara would hear.

"What was that?" Mara asked. She did hear. She was in the doorway of my RV with a bottle of water and a handful of napkins, looking in the direction of the butte where Otto had called out.

What can I say? I was drunk, I was panicking. This was something new I couldn't have predicted. *I have to lie, I need to come up with an excuse and maybe it will blow over*.

I can't say it's a coyote or a wolf, it's clearly not an animal of any kind.

There's no transformers or phone polls in that direction so it can't be that.

Mara was looking at me now.

"I -" I was frozen and I wasn't hiding it well, "I don't know."

"It sounded like a rocket taking off, my god." Mara walked over to me and wiped the blood from my nose. My eyes were still trained on the cave.

"Maybe someone is behind the butte with some friends?" I scrambled. I could feel sweat forming, gripping my shirt to my skin.

"Doing what?" Mara turned away from me after making sure I took a sip from the water and wandered over to the edge of the hill. She was looking directly at the butte. I held my breath like it was the only thing keeping Otto hidden still. "*HELLO?*" Mara called out in response.

Without a moment of pause Otto called out again - his echoey roar scratching deep into my ears, and Mara's by the looks of her. We both crumbled to the ground. I could feel my ribs vibrating against my muscles. Again my glasses slipped from my nose and fell into the dirt, more blood dripped out from my face, slipping out of both nostrils now. I tasted iron and spat out a wad of blood, rum and spit.

My vision went dark. I could feel myself straining to wheeze air in and out of my lungs between globs of bile and blood. I was shaking.

I tried to look around but with every turn of my head I was stung with a flash of blurry images.

The foot of the butte.

The mouth of the cave.

My feet walking across the desert.

My hands furiously scribbling together reports.

Otto was calling for me.

My vision returned.

Mara was on her knees and looked back at me in bewilderment. She could see blood coating my mouth and chin, staining the neckline of my shirt.

"Howard what's happening?!" Mara cried.

I looked toward the butte, the calling had stopped, but I knew if I ignored him again it would start back.

Mara was too kind. She wouldn't let me go alone, especially not in my current state. I could run and hope she doesn't find me, but there aren't many places to hide in the desert.

I could bring her with me, Otto might still prefer me to her for my loyalty. Maybe he would equally accept both of us.

My options were limited and poor.

"It's coming from the cave." I muttered.

"What cave?" Mara's brow furrowed.

I scrambled to my feet and moved to help her up. Standing by her I turned her body to face the butte and pointed at the cave. I waited for her eyes to align with my finger.

"Do you see it?"

Mara was silent a moment before whispering as though someone would hear, "What is that?"

I took a deep breath and swallowed my blood and my pride, "Let's look."

To my surprise, there was little protest from Mara. Scientists curiosity I suppose, the urge to explore the unknown. The ongoing search for answers.

We walked down the hill together, carefully, like we were approaching a deer and trying not to scare it off. Mara was doing it out of fear of what was lurking in the cave we were approaching, I was doing it out of fear that Otto might not approve of our speed and call out again in impatience. My body already felt like it had been squeezed like an orange, I don't know what more Otto could do to me - but the possibilities that ran through my head frightened me.

It was a long and quiet march through the desert to reach the butte. The sounds of our feet shuffling across the sand and little critters hidden by the night chirping quiet songs accompanied our trek. Neither of us spoke. Neither of us looked at each other.

We had reached the butte. I could hear the humming before I was even facing the cave. It felt like anger or hunger; a ravenous growl stronger than the gentle lure I had first encountered.

Mara was first to reach the mouth of the cave. Her mouth was agape as her head slowly rolled in a circle, taking in the amazing spectacle of the tendriled obscurity before her. I joined her at her side and looked in, trying hard to look surprised.

I had to find a way for her to forget this, lose interest, or become as enthralled by it as myself. No one could forget an encounter like this, nor would they lose interest. Especially not someone like Mara or myself, and I don't doubt Ron would have his interest in the specimen either. Which left one option.

"Mara…" I said softly, splitting the silent air.

"I have no idea what I'm even looking at…" Mara uttered, shaking her head and ignoring my regard.

"We should examine it." I offered.

Mara was quiet again. I noticed her expression harden at my suggestion, though she didn't turn to look at me; her eyes remained transfixed on the black appendages spiraling into the cavern.

I must sound like a moron. Or like I'm crazy. Or like a crazy moron.

"How would we do that?" Mara finally added. There were no notes of hostility or disdain in her voice. *This may go better than expected*.

I just needed to push a little harder, "We go in."

"Go in? Howard we don't know what that thing is. Is it man made, is it toxic, is it an animal?"

"I don't know what it is," I wasn't lying, I didn't know what Otto was, only that his nature was foreign, cosmic, and he enjoyed exchanging memories with me, "but do you feel that?"

"What?" Mara finally looked to me again.

"That humming?" I prayed in my head that she too felt her thoughts going quiet, her worries melting away, and that there might be a gentle tugging at her brain to come further into the cave.

"I think so…" Mara nodded.

"Maybe we should follow it." I suggested taking a step closer to Otto, but Mara's hand shot out and gripped my arm.

"*Howard!*" She hissed like an angry mother, "You're not only going against everything we've learned in school and our careers about safety - you're going against basic *instinct*. Why would we wander blindly into something this *weird?!*"

She was speaking honestly, any smart person would have listened to common sense and stayed away, maybe called the government or a lab. *I guess I wasn't as smart as I thought I was*.

Mara continued, "Honestly Howard, the only reason anyone would go in there is if they were an *idiot* or if they already knew what-..."

Mara stopped herself, and in that break in her sentence my heart stopped for a moment too. Mara stared into my eyes with a look of shock and betrayal, her hand still held firmly around my arm. I can only imagine how I must look right now.

Bloodied, disheveled, tense and afraid, trying desperately to hide it all. *Caught*.

"Howard." Mara's tone was firm, not friendly. Like a professor who had caught a student cheating. "What's in there?"

"Please just come with me…" I pleaded. I had no plan for this, I didn't know it would get this far. There was no other move I could conjure other than to beg for solidarity.

"No!"

"Please!" I barked, more harshly than I had intended. "*Please*…" I brought myself back down.

Mara looked first into the cave, then back at me.

"I'll follow behind you." She said.

There was no expression for me to read on her face other than vague disgust - *disgust in me and my lies*. No tone for me to take hints from either. I could only hope she was telling the truth. That she would follow behind me and understand. What choice did I have? If I protested she certainly wouldn't come in.

"Alright." I agreed, relieved slightly that there would be some form of conclusion to this encounter.

I turned away from Mara and began walking steadily into Otto. I heard footsteps not far behind me as my feet set on Otto's surface and pressed deeper into the darkness.

The humming filled my ears and my mind began going blank. I was calming down, forgetting the stress I had been experiencing all night. I fought to keep my wits about me for just a moment longer.

"Are you behind me?" I called back in a groggy voice.

An unintelligible muffled garble responded that I could only assume was a "Yes" from Mara. I went further and further, feeling my muscles relax until I lost control over my legs, started to the ground, and everything went dark.

The flashes began, this time of planets and asteroids. Beautiful, all of them.

Then my offering to Otto:

Technology - computer - electricity

Light - flash - dark

Body - phone - Mara

Hot - weather - cold

Picture - video - movie

Angry - Afraid - Emotion

Mara - Break - Break

Break - Break - Cooler.

***

I was awake in my bed and I was uncomfortable. My clothes felt wet and clung to my body. My skin felt crackled and itchy and my whole body ached. I was hungry and thirsty. Anything that could feel unpleasant did feel unpleasant.

I sat up and jumped back at the first thing I saw.

Blood.

Everywhere. On my floor, on the desk, on the walls, on my bed, on *me*. Not just dripping from my nose and mouth but coating my shirt, hands and face.

Mara was nowhere in sight.

Shaking and shuddering for breath I rose from my bed and walked across the red floor to the outside of my RV to look around.

"Mara?" I cried out in a weak voice. Hoping, *hoping* so desperately she would respond.

There was none. Her car was where she had left it.

I looked to the cave, there was nothing strange about the cave or the butte, *nothing stranger than Otto at least*. The scene of the massacre seemed contained to the RV, inside and out.

I examined the scene closer and noticed a distinct trail of blood leading from the steps of my RV to the edge of the hill where sat my cooler.

Hesitantly I approached it. The closer I came I noticed blood on the outside, staining the already red exterior. Handprints on the top, splatters on the bottom and sides with notable chunks of remain - *impact marks*.

I forced one of my hands forward, unable to look anywhere or do anything else. I opened the cooler and inside was what was left of Mara.

3
The Cycle

Mara didn't get the funeral she deserved; surrounded by family, friends and colleagues all saying kind words and sharing stories of her kindness and achievements.

Instead, I buried her no more than 3 feet deep in the desert sand, near the foot of the hill my RV was stationed on, with a cooler as her casket.

The day I found her dead was the longest day I had ever experienced. I hardly spoke, I couldn't find any words that would work in my mouth and there were none that were appropriate for the situation.

I gazed at her remains for a long time. Her hands and feet were thrown haphazardly on top of her arms, which twisted grotesquely at the edges of the cooler and grossly framed the visible half of Mara's head - which, from what I could see - was frozen perpetually in vague shock. Eyes dry and wide open with her mouth slightly agape. The unevenly snapped edges of bones stuck out awkwardly from various points of the remains, and everything was covered in a thick layer of dirty blood.

I threw up, exhausting myself even more. I voided what little I had in my stomach and then some, with vile chunks of damaged flesh from my throat joining the watery gallons that came out of me. Once I caught my breath I saw that I had mostly missed the cooler, but one of her arms and a foot had been covered in a notable bit of residual vomit.

I closed the cooler.

I took a deep breath, stood, and reentered my RV. I washed my mouth and face and when I returned outside the RV I was holding a bowl of milk and cereal that I ate on the steps - staring anywhere but the cooler.

My eyes landed on her 4-wheeler. I couldn't leave it there, I had to find a way to hide it or destroy it.

I finished my cereal and left the bowl on the stairs before wandering silently down to the 4-wheeler, only to realize the keys weren't in the ignition. I walked back up and checked in and around the RV to no avail. There was only one other possible location.

I dug my bare hand into the gruesome mess I had made in the cooler, my fingers sliding uncomfortably through the sticking blood and the cold skin. My hand touched the bottom of the cooler, where a good inch of blood and pus had pooled. My fingers swam in the foul muck until they found a short piece of jagged metal. I gripped it firmly and pulled it free, scraping my hand against exposed bone and unintentionally dragging Mara's left foot out of the cooler.

With my arm covered in gruelly muck I marched pitifully back down to the 4-wheeler, got in, and started it up.

I drove north, where Mara came down from. I wasn't going to drive all the way back to her location, I couldn't feasibly walk back. It was an hour to her base. I would drive 15 minutes, find a butte or a ditch, or some discrete corner that I could tuck the vehicle away in and hope to God it was never found.

After 15 minutes of driving it was decided; a ditch. I found a good slump in the sand far enough away where you couldn't clearly make out any signs of my base. I drove the 4-wheeler to the edge of the ditch, stepped out carefully and pushed with all the power I could muster - which thankfully was enough to send it careening into the shallow pit, lightly dented with the wheels up and the drivers door ajar.

The wind would hopefully blow enough sand over it where it wouldn't be found for quite some time, but my part was done and I started the long walk home.

An hour later I was back at my little mound and the sun was edging quickly to the west.

Next, I returned to the cooler and replaced Mara's foot back in to the messy collection before shutting the lid and carrying it down. It's weight made it uncomfortable and difficult to hold easily, I was worried I would slip or need to set it down and all of Mara's awfulness would spill out into the sand. The image of having to retrieve and reorganize the remains of my friend into a cooler made my heart drop into my stomach. I wanted to vomit again but I fought hard to hold it down, at least until the work was done.

At the base of the hill I found a shadowy pocket with loose sand that I was able to pull apart with my hands. I dug for half an hour or so before my hands were sore, caked in thick mud, and the I was kneeling before looked deep enough to house Mara's remains. Gently, I placed the cooler in the hole in the ground and stared for a long while, the desert sun beaming against my face.

Then I uttered the only words I could remember saying all evening (other than the odd curse here and there), "I'm so sorry."

They meant nothing.

I threw the sand and dirt I had ripped up from the earth on top of the cooler and tapped it down as evenly as possible.

I returned to the top of the hill and looked down at the burial site. If any stray person were to come by for any reason they wouldn't be able to tell there was anything hidden there. But I could tell. Something about that imperfect hole I had carved was still visible to me, and that knowledge burned a fear that anyone who happened upon that spot would know. Everyone would know.

I was tired. I was in shock. I was sick and covered in filth and I wanted to shower. But walking past my empty bowl of cereal I realized there was still more work to do.

I washed and scrubbed every surface, bloodied or not, in and out of the RV. I threw my sheets and pillows in the garbage, there was no salvaging them. My clothes too. I needed everything to be purified.

By sunset I couldn't detect any trace of the massacre other than the blackened dry blood that caked my arms, neck and face. Finally, I showered. I stood in the water until it went cold.

Once I was clean I walked out and stood in my RV, dripping and naked. I felt different.

There's no one right way to describe how I felt; different. Numb. *Wrong*.

My friend was massacred by my hand last night and I've spent the whole day covering it up, and now, as the sun begins to set, all I can think of is Otto.

It was late and I had worked hard all day. A knot of nausea sat heavily in my stomach still, and I hadn't stopped to see Otto all day.

I could stand to get some work done. I could use some rest.

Keep up appearances, act normal, and maybe Ron would assume Mara got lost in a sandstorm, got in a car wreck, or just up and left.

I could find a way to keep everything under wraps but for now I needed rest. I needed Otto.

I journeyed to the cave and silently wandered in and was happily accepted by the darkness.

***

I firmly believe that if a zookeeper were to give a smart enough gorilla a gun and a loaded magazine it could take over the zoo in a **day**.

Similarly, I believe that salmon are able to recall their home streams despite having the brain of a fish because of a natural magnetic effect similar to the draw Otto has had on me in recent weeks.

It is worth noting that I haven't eaten or drank much other than the occasional bottle of water, a bag of chips, and some rather strong edibles I found left behind by Mara - whose 1-week death anniversary it was yesterday.

It is also worth noting that Ron has had remarkably little to say to me. The day after I buried Mara I received exactly 3 messages from him that went as follows:

RON: "Where is Mara?"

Myself: "She and I spent the day together yesterday."

RON: “Where is she now?”

Myself: “She left late last night, I assume she is back at her base.”

RON: “Alright.”

“*Alright*.” is the only semblance of reassurance I have received that all is well on Ron’s end and mine - that nobody knows what happened.

I know and Otto knows and that’s all that matters.

Otto has been restless lately - his pull has been gradually getting stronger. The past 2 days have been a pattern of wandering into the cave of the butte, waking up several hours later to eat or drink something before feeling the overwhelming urge to wander back in.

In just the past week alone I’ve noticed myself losing weight. I don’t know exactly how many pounds but I could only make out the outline of my ribcage two weeks ago, and now I can see each rib more prominently.

I was getting my cardio in at least - walking to and from Otto’s cave every day multiple times a day in the desert works up a sweat, and a tiny bit of muscle in the legs.

Otherwise, I looked sick. My skin, tanned by the desert sun, now faded into some tone of grayed peach. My eyes hung with dark haunted wreaths and my hair was greasy and poorly kempt. I had stopped changing my clothes after my visits with Otto; interims between visits were too short to justify going through so many shirts and shorts.

I had continued uploading Otto’s findings. Looking at the bar graph known as the “productivity tracker” Ron had set up, my red line stood out tall and proud well beyond Ron’s measly green line. It reached just over halfway the height of my own - 24 documents from Ron compared to my 45. Mara’s blue bar hung notably below the both of ours. Before her passing, it stood almost identically to Ron’s but with her gone the numbers dwindled significantly.

It hardly mattered. Anything she would have found in the next month is probably already sitting in my cabinet in a neatly stacked paper arrangement.

The last upload of mine was an hour ago.

Ron hasn’t checked it.

It wasn’t uncommon for documents to be left unchecked until several hours past their submission, sometimes they won’t be checked until the next day.

Ron hasn’t checked any of my submissions in 2.

He knows something. Something about my papers being prewritten before their submission, about Otto, about Mara. I'm at a disadvantage, in the dark. I don't know what he knows.

Be reasonable. Be logical. He can't know anything. No one else lives out in this desert, at least not close enough to have seen or heard anything that happened. There have been no news vans, no hikers, no police, no passing RVs, nothing. There's no way Ron can know. Right?

It was then that some 50 or so milligrams of THC hit me from a couple of Mara's edibles I had eaten earlier in the day. It took me by surprise and I was trying to gauge how it made me feel. Before it had made me heavyheaded, hungry, dry mouthed and everything was a little bit funnier. This time, my body felt tight. My heart was beating what felt harder than normal and I couldn't make out the correct sizes of my bed or desk or doorway. I was panicking.

Otto can fix this.

Once again I marched to the cave as I had so many times before and as I stood at the mouth of the cave and stared into the darkness.

Otto's tendrils writhed gently over each other, eagerly waiting for me to fall into them. As I stared longingly at the abyss, like an insomniac stares at a silk pillow, my heart feels heavy.

But it's not the memory of Mara that hurts, it's Otto. I felt it on the walk and I feel it now staring at him. *Pause*. Doubt and maybe even fatigue.

Fatigue - that's it. Exhaustion. Every day I have to walk 10 minutes to Otto just to turn my mind off at get work done. Is it even my work? I spent so many years in school, so much money, so much debt to know how to do my work and do it well. Now, I don't use any of it. I'm just a tool with knowledge and skills for Otto to use.

A low growl came from deep within Otto. It sounded hungry, and that sound alone quieted my mind. A wave of guilt washed over me for questioning Otto. He's helping me do my best work, I shouldn't take that for granted. He wouldn't even let Mara be a vessel. *I'm special to him*.

Tucking away any doubt from in mind I began wandering into the cave. Then deeper. Then even deeper. Then I reached a point I had never reached before. My mind was quiet but not numb like it usually was when I entered Otto. I felt hazy as I looked all around me. An enormous opening in the cave, with walls that rounded high above me into a rough circular underground pocket. It took a while for my eyes to adjust to the darkness but once they did I could see:

Black limbs surrounding the cave entirely, thicker and beating harder than the ones that stretches to the mouth of the cave. I could hear the beating of the limbs like a heart, each of them pulsing individually and indiscriminate from each other that the harmony of pumping rings together as a deafening hum.

I felt my mind start to go but I continued to survey.

In the last few moments of consciousness I had I noticed breaks between some of the tentacles in several spots with a similar wet bulbous shape peaking out. I couldn't make out the color - in this darkness everything blended in as a shade of black and gray. But I could see the bulb moving differently than the tendrils, not bulging with a pulse but darting left and right; moving with me as I swayed gently, trying to stay conscious.

They were dozens of eyes surrounding me, studying me, as my knees gave out and my head started for the floor. Then, I was gone again.

Large intestine - Kidney - Liver

Brain - Skull - Vein

Skin - Teeth - Muscle

Rectum - Blood - Heart

Tongue - Eye - Lung.

***

I've been thinking a lot about my birth. It was the only time I've ever been truly connected to another being - until Otto, at least.

I don't remember being born but I imagine it must have been as clashingly jarring and serene as it is connecting with Otto. A birth in reverse.

I do wish a little that Mara could experience it too. And Ron. It feels strange that I alone understand this feeling - that Otto dropped out of the sky and found me alone to share wisdom with.

I see a new star - then I'm shown an aquatic pit lined with crystals that can open and close its opening and boil the water within it to kill any idle fish or swimming creatures caught inside. A crystalline cave that eats. Fascinating.

Then, another star. Another star. And another.

Then a planet colored a deep orange with blue marbling - patches of water here and there, large lakes scattered all around but no ocean.

More and more stars.

I'm ready to wake up. I'm ready to be born again.

***

I feel **strange**.

I feel *new*.

There is an **emptiness** inside me that I haven't known before. Like something is missing.

I don't awake in my bed like **normal**. Instead I wake in the desert. Standing at the foot of the hill that leads up to my RV.

The change is sudden and unexpected. I fall to my knees and wheeze in exhaustion. I don't know why I'm outside. I don't know where my work is.

I gather my thoughts.

The sun is up. It must be morning.
My stomach feels empty. I haven't eaten.
There's a soreness in my bones.
I must have been working.
There is a car nearby.

*There is a **car**.*

It isn't mine and I can feel this strange delirium overwhelming me again. It's hard to think straight. To keep everything aligned right.

I can't tell if this is **stress**, some kind of **stroke**, or **something** else that Otto did to me.

Settle down.

Think

Straight.

Think Straight

THINK

STRAIGHT

THINK STRAIGHT.

It isn't my car.
I recognize it.
Barely.
A 4-wheeler.
Red.
Similar model to **Mara's**, but older.

I approach it. I **Inspect** it.

There is a **decoration** dangling from the rear view mirror.

A monopoly figure of a **Jockey** on a horse.

It's Ron's car. I know it is.

He isn't in the car which means he's near.

I don't know how long he's been here or how much he's **seen**. I'm suddenly all too aware of how I look. My entire body is caked in sand, my hair and glasses too. Dry **blood** covers my nose and mouth, stretching down along my neck too.

I look **insane**.

Act. **Normal**.

I just need to act normal. If I do that well enough he won't be able to tell what's been happening.

I bring myself to my feet and start marching up the hill to my RV. I'm breathing heavy. It's hard to tell if I'm in **control**. It takes me a moment to realize that my body is moving. I can't feel my feet moving. They just **are**.

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

My arm reaches up to open the door to the RV on its own and reels it open. I step in and look around. I survey my bed, the couch, the shower, the kitchen, my desk. I don't see **Ron**.

Maybe he's gone somewhere else.

"Howard."

Ron is sitting on the couch.

I looked there.

His **eyes** look sunken in behind his glasses, his beard looks grayer and his mouth is in its iconic ever present scowl. His voice swims in my ears like a worm buried deep in the wrinkles of my brain. His mouth is moving but so many of his words are muffled and turn into bitter wax - but a select few phrases; the important things, the things I need to react to are clear and painful.

"What have you been doing?"

His voice is bold. Taking up the entire **room**. It shakes me.

"What do you mean?" I say.

"What do you do to get all those reports, Howard?"

He knows about the reports.

Maybe not all of them,

but a lot of them.

"I don't know what you mean, Ron."

"I didn't know you were coming in, Ron."

I don't know which one I say. Maybe I say **both** of them? I can't **feel** my mouth moving.

"What did you do to Mara?"

He knows something happened to Mara.

Not exactly what, but he knows **something**.

And he knows I **did** it.

How?

Ron being here in front of me, my mobility lacking, him knowing and asking me all these questions…

It's my worst nightmare sitting in my RV.

"We talked."

"I killed her."

"We got drunk."

What did I say? **What** am I saying?

Why can't I feel my mouth?

I hear the words but I don't know which ones are in my head and which ones are **real**.

Ron stands up.

He moves close to me, he's inches away.

"I know there was more than that, Howard."

"What do you mean?"

He pulls his phone out from his pocket. **Mara**.
he pulls up messages between himself and **her**.

At the top of the screen it says: "Heading over to see **Howard**, I'll text you soon."

Then, There's a video.

Ron presses **play**.

"Are you behind me?"

I hear my own voice play from the video.

"Yeah, Howard, I'm behind you."

Mara responded, but she isn't following me. She's standing still at the mouth of the cave recording everything. She never went in.

A minute passes, and then I emerge from the cave. My eyes wide and my mouth agape. I look lost, like I'm looking for something.

"Howard?"

Mara asks for me, but my eyes move beyond her. I don't acknowledge her. I just walk back to my RV. Mara follows me.

In moments I'm surrounded by papers with 2 pens in my hands and I'm scribbling like a madman. My hands are moving like a printer - surgical and precise. Perfect formatting, and then the pages are done. Then I begin again, and the pattern repeats. Stacks after stacks of these go on and Mara attempts to interject only once or twice.

After about a dozen papers are done in only a few minutes, Mara pushes me over.

"What the hell are you doing Howard? What's wrong with you?"

I'm staring at her now, I see her.

"Do you need help? Are you sick? What happened in the cave?"

My brow begins to furrow in the video, and I see a plan forming in my dilated eyes.

"Let me help you."

Mara offers, extending a hand out to me.

Then, I move. I jump at her and animalistic sounds grumble out of my throat as I push Mara to the ground and I'm on top of her.

Her phone clatters to the ground next to her and my face is visible in the top right corner.

I'm clawing at her, and beating away her hands as they try to push me away.

Then, I raise my fists and bring them down hard.

Then again, Then again, Then again, Then again, Then again, Then again, Then again.

Chunk. Chunk. Chunk. Chunk. Chunk. Chunk. Chunk.

Blood **covers** part of the screen, and what can be seen of me.

On screen, I'm **panting** gruffly. Mara isn't breathing at all.

The video continues and I hear **ripping**.

Cutting. Stretching. Pounding. Squelching. Squishing. Breaking. Tearing. Grinding. Snapping.

Ron fast forwards.

Then a **cooler** lid shuts.

Phone.

"I want to hear it from you, Howard."

Ron demands.

"I killed her."

"I killed her."

"I killed her."

I **admit**.

"I had to kill her.

I have to kill you.

I can kill you too.

I can kill you."

I don't **know** if I say any or all of that.

But either way, I've told Ron everything he needs to know.

Think.

Think.

Think.

He needs to **die**.

I'll **strangle** him.

I'll **stab** him with my pens.

I'll **crush** him with my desk.

"Where is the cave Howard?"

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

He asks.

How is he so calm?

Otto.

Otto can fix this.

The idea must have **shown** on my face.

Ron says:

"Don't run. Don't fight them."

"Them?"

Sirens. Police.

I look out my window and see 3 vans pull up to the bottom of the hill.

4 **officers** start running up the hill to me.

"Go quietly, Howard."

"No." I defy.

I jump on Ron and get my hands around his neck but he's bigger than me, **stronger** than me. My grip is tight on his throat and without him able to get a breath in before, he **chokes** a bit before reeling back and plunging his fist hard into my **gut**. I **wretch** and keel over.

I try to catch my breath, it's **impossible**.

I **hear** voices behind me.

"Hands behind your head!"
"Stay on the ground!" "We will shoot!"

Breathless, I still find the strength to stand. 4 cops block the doorway to the RV and Ron is still on the ground, coughing.

I need to get to Otto.

I rush to the door and jump, the officers don't **expect** it and I'm able to split my way between two of them.

I begin **tumbling** down the near perfectly vertical hill. I'm falling fast and I'm even more discombobulated than before. More officers exit the vans and move to me.

There is a long journey between me and the **cave**.

But I can try.

At a quick glance behind me I see the officers charging down. Ron is staying in the RV. He's going to find everything, but it's out of my control now.

It's all out of control.

I rise from the ground unsure of my footing but sure of my direction. It feels like there's a magnet in my head drawing me toward the cave and I begin to run.

I'm faster than before. At least I **think** I am. I **feel** like I am.

I'm running and running and **running** and running.

I hear **yelling** behind me.

Then engines starting up.

Then gunshots.

BANG!

BANG!

BANG!

BANG! ***BANG!***

BANG!

BANG!

BANG!

Three shots hit me.

One in my right **calf**.

One through my **side**.

Another in my left **shoulder**.

Everything burns and I feel myself slowing down and the roaring wheels of the vans gaining on me as I run to the cave.

I can see it. I'm so close.

He's going to **save** me.

BANG!

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Another bullet hits my left thigh. Both of my legs are injured and I'm at the foot of the **butte**.

My **glasses** clatter to the ground and break. Everything is blurry and I continue to crawl, scraping over my broken glasses. Moving closer and closer to the mouth of the cave. I can see the black tendrils. He's still there.

Darkness **creeps** in at the edges of my vision. And I know I'm **fading**.

BANG! ***BANG!***

Two misses, which I'm thankful for. One more shot

and **surely** I'm dead.

I crawl further, every muscle and bone on fire. Bloody and muddy as My fingers wrap around the tentacle nearest to the edge of the cave.

Then Otto's tendrils wrap around **my** arm, linking us together.

They pull me in, more and more tendrils coil around my body, drawing me deeper into the cave.

The yelling of officers continue behind me. They're close.

"Save Me."

I **beg**.

I'm drawn into the massive pocket I saw last time before going dark...
I don't feel like I'm being saved.

Dozens of eyes stare at me as I bleed out on a bed of tentacles.

They tightly wrap around my body and **draw** me up.

They lift me **higher**, holding me against the wall.

Covering my body.

My arms, my torso, my legs, my neck, my left eye, all covered.

Then my bullet wounds, I feel the tendrils entering them. It stings and I feel my damaged flesh being pushed open further and unwelcome dark strands worming their way under my skin, splitting through my muscles, and holding my body in a firm position -

I can't escape the tendrils - I can't get them out of me.

They've amalgamated with my skin.

My body is stretched further than it should be. Everything is pushed to its limit. I feel Otto's tendrils wrapping over my humerus', wriggling up under the skin of my palms holding my hands down at opposite ends. I'm struggling to breathe, and every movement is joined with a jolt of stabbing discomfort.

I hear more gunshots.

And then I hear **screams**.

More guns and more **screams**.

Even more guns.

Even more **screams**.

Then silence.

This is the **last** thing I hear before my hearing goes.

I don't go deaf, but everything sounds like it's **underwater**, muffled.

My throat feels tight and I try to speak but only wheeze. No words come out, only

Sounds.

I don't feel the burning as strongly anymore. My whole body is riddled with uncomfortable stinging numbness, like everything is falling asleep.

But my eyes stay open. My **eyes** still work.

Then my mind.

Officer - Gun - Bullet

Pistol - Rifle - Machine

Van - Car - Truck

Wound - Blood - Shot.

He's learning.

He's learning but I'm still awake.

Now I'm awake, but I wasn't just a moment ago…When **he** started thinking.

But now I'm thinking, and he's quiet…

Rock - Planet - Earth

WRITTEN WORK OF CONNOR WRAY

Mars - Jupiter - Mercury
Solar System - Milky Way - Sun

Jesus.

I'm back again.

I'm not seeing stars anymore.

He can show me. I know he can show me, but he won't. Why won't he? **Why the hell won't he show me the stars anymore?**

Moon - Stars - Asteroid - Meteor - Stone - Ice - Comet - Telescope - Microscope - Periscope - Stethoscope - Doctor - Nurse - Vet - Therapist - Mind - Fix - Help - Diagnose - Disease - Brain - Illness - Sickness - Plague - Famine - Death - Virus - Spread - Wide - Cover - Stretch - Blanket - Conquer - Overwhelm - Overpower - Command - Demand - Own - Power - King - Queen - Prince - Princess - Monarch - President - Dictator - Emperor - Lord - Kingdom - Providence - State - Country - Territory - Ownership - Buy - Sell - Trade - Offer - Covet - Envy - Pride - Sin - Repent - Church - Faith - Christ - Bhuddah - Yaweh - Rah - Set - Zeus - Odin - Thor - Poseidon - Greece - Switzerland - Sweden - Rome - France - England - Ship - Migration - Birds - Colony - Puritan - History - Burn - Witch - Trial - Legend - Wolf - Vampire - Atlantis - Fiction - Fantasy - Books - Movies - Theatre - Acting - Directing - Writing - Poetry - Scripts - Novels - Essays - Reports - News - Papers - Notebook - Journal - Travel - World - Study - Explore - Native - Visit - Belief - Practice - Tradition - Study - Education - School - University - Professor - Teacher - Student - Class - Major - Minor - Certificate - Degree - Career - Job - Labor - Slave - Work - Pay - Salary - Hours - Train - Discipline - Demand - Supply - Money - Wealth - Freedom

I can't breathe.

I **can't** fucking breathe.

But I'm still alive. And I saw the **stars** again.

I saw the stars and blood red oceans that spanned whole worlds. I see storms that never end and never move. Animals eating themselves and being born again from their remains. Forests on opposite ends of a planet connected by roots and vines the size of highways that span miles through the worlds crust. White fire spewing from skies, fungi that melds with any animal and plant that dies upon it, pink turf and black stars. Suns exploding and destroying entire systems.

Flashes of a thousand different images captured by a thousand eyes all flooding my mind while my own experience is being drawn out of me.

I feel like I'm melting. All I have are brief moments to come up for air when he's not invading my thoughts.

He wants me so that he can understand my world, our way. But what's his plan? Why does he need this?

I'm never going to know. I can't see anything outside of this pocket - other than what he shows me. And I can't move my arms or legs - he won't let me.

I'm a textbook on **rental**.
I'm a piece of **hardware** with extra data.
I'm something to enjoy in his **spare** time.
He'll use me **until** he has everything and then…

Oh God.

I want to go.
I want to go home.
I want to go anywhere else.
I want to go back to **Cornell**.

I'm just as trapped in here as I was there. Everything I worked so hard to become an expert in being used by someone else. By something else. My intelligence - everything I am - being picked apart and chosen like **grapes** from the vine.

I'm stuck.

In a cycle I'll **never** see the **end** of. I'm going to keep going under over and over again until I die here.

Im **afraid.** I don't know where I'm going, what's going to happen to me, or who else may have or may come to suffer the same fate as me.

I may leave my planet and never know. All I am is a **speck** of knowledge being swallowed by a universe - I'm a projector showing images of a beautiful world used to lure in another fool too curious for their own good. I'm one of many victims, I'm sure.

I'm about to go back under, I can feel it. I choke in as many breaths as I can, and I don't know when or if I'm going to come back up again.

Mara… I'm so **sorry**.

THE END.